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LUKAS ROSOL

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Lukas Rosol is a former top-30 player in the ATP Rankings. He was a member of the Czechia team that won the Davis Cup titles in 2012 and 2013 although he did not feature in either summit clash. He also went on to win two titles on the ATP Tour.

But perhaps, the biggest moment of Rosol's career came during Wimbledon 2012 when he stunned two-time champion Rafael Nadal in five sets in the second round.

Now, at the age of 38 and ranked 881 in the world, Rosol is close to the end of his career.

In a virtual interaction with *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the fifth season of the Tennis Premier League, the 6'4" Czech player spoke about the next generation of men's tennis from his country, Nadal's much-awaited comeback in 2024 and more.

You're someone who has played tennis at the highest level but in recent years it's been a bit tough for you to play consistently and make it to the main draws of the Slams. Being on the wrong side of 30, how tough is it for you to motivate yourself to keep pushing? Do you have a goal that you want to achieve before retiring?

It's very simple. As I have been playing for so long already (21

seasons), you just have to love tennis. I'm not doing it for money. I'm not doing it to show somebody that I will win against this guy or that guy or to win a tournament. If I win a match, it's for me. It's just a great feeling and these endorphins which you get from winning the match, you cannot buy or get somewhere. But, I think next year, I won't play much because I have a little son now. I would like to stay with him a lot and enjoy family time a little bit. Yes, it's time to say goodbye slowly. I haven't decided yet which date it will be but the new players are so strong and so fast. It's tough to play them.

What are your thoughts on the next generation of men's tennis in Czechia with the likes of Jiri Lehecka, Tomas Machac and Jakub Mensik?

After guys like (Tomas) Berdych and (Radek) Stepanek, there was a gap for a couple of years and I was sceptical. There were no players and if there were, they were around 300-400 rank. But they started to work on themselves. Lehecka, Machac and some of these young prospects are starting to play better and better. Their rank has started to improve. Lehecka is around 30 but top 20 is another step which he has to make. Machac, hopefully, is going to be in the top 100 longer than he has been so far. Mensik has a future. He has a good body and serves very

well. We also have more top women's players than men. There are always at least 7-8 Czech women in the top 100. (Petra) Kvitova and (Karolina) Pliskova are slowly finishing their careers but there are a couple of new players like (Linda) Noskova. She was in the final in Auckland and is also good.

What do tournaments like Tennis Premier League and other leagues that take place at the end of the season mean in the current tennis ecosystem?

As many kids come to watch the sport, it is going to be more famous. It's not a bad idea to do this because if 300-400 kids come from schools everyday, they will start to like it. And even if five kids everyday start to play tennis, it's amazing. This is a great opportunity for them to start building something. Even if maybe two-three players come through, they will learn at a really good level and India will have new stars.

2012 was a great year for you since you won the Davis Cup and also, famously beat Rafael Nadal in the second round at Wimbledon. Can you share some memories from that match?

I won the first round against (Ivan) Dodig and then, I played Rafa in the second round. I was nervous and scared because it was my first time on Centre Court. It's like the best